understanding of India's nuclear tests than other P-5 states, intensified rapidly in the triad of defence, nuclear and space. Each of these trends was to continue for the next decade and a half as India strove to shape global outcomes by shifting its weight in various directions on different issues. That worked so long as there was a stable balance based on the pre-eminence of the US with other major powers offsetting its influence. But as American dominance reduced and the power of China rose sharply, the changing landscape made the old calculation increasingly difficult to practice.

In the period when India was balancing a dynamic situation, a development that merits special mention is the 2005 Indo-US nuclear deal. It does so because this agreement removed key impediments to the development of those ties and enabled them to reach the stage they have today. In addition, it helped shape the global perception of India and has surely contributed to the higher stature it now enjoys. In its essence, the deal sought to put aside prohibitions on nuclear cooperation that had a ripple impact on defence, on dual-use technology, and on space cooperation. By making an exception, it changed sentiment in India about the US very substantially.

From the American side, there was little doubt that the growing relevance of Asia was a key factor in driving a stronger relationship with a democratic and market-oriented India. Debates within our country on this issue are well known and centred around a political suspicion of the US, implications for the nuclear weapon programme and pressures on the relationship with Iran. Despite the radical nature of the initiative and the extremely complicated negotiations that arose due to the cooperation being predicated on legislation, India was able to ensure a successful outcome. It also paved the way for an exception to be made by the Nuclear Suppliers Group that contributed to negating the perception of India as an outlier in an important area. This visible spike in a relationship with the premier power naturally put pressure for growth in other ties. It produced immediate gains because key European powers and Russia were supportive for their own reasons. At that time, China's relations with both India and the US were sufficiently cooperative as to support an NSG waiver decision. A few years later, changed global equations produced very different results.